The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Oil prices rose despite the **International Energy Agency** announcing it would release an unprecedented 400m barrels of oil from its reserves. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped back past $100 a barrel during early trading in Asia. It is now back below that mark. The blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has curtailed global oil supply by roughly 20m barrels a day.

The **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps**, the Iranian regime's security forces, warned countries to "get ready for oil to be $200 a barrel". Iran struck several more vessels in the Persian Gulf. Two were set ablaze off the coast of Iraq; another, near Dubai, sustained a small fire overnight on Wednesday. Meanwhile Israel launched an "expansive wave of strikes" on Beirut, Lebanon's capital.

The **Pentagon** reportedly told Congress that the first six days of the war in Iran cost America more than $11bn. It also said it was investigating a strike on a girls' school in Iran, which killed 175 people. According to the *New York Times*, a preliminary investigation found that the building was targeted as a result of outdated American intelligence data. President Donald Trump had previously blamed Iran.

China approved a law that will force the country's **ethnic minorities** to learn Mandarin, the language of the dominant Han Chinese group. It will become the main language in schools and official communication. The legislation also calls for "new social customs" to encourage living in mixed communities. Critics say that the law on "ethnic harmony" will further marginalise several of China's 56 ethnicities.

America launched investigations into several of its trading partners, including the EU, **China**, **Japan** and **India**. The probes will examine their alleged "excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors", but are seen as a precursor for the Trump administration to raise new duties on imports. America's Supreme Court struck down many of Mr Trump's tariffs last month, but he vowed to reimpose them.

Atlassian said that it would axe 1,600 staff, about 10% of its global workforce. Mike Cannon-Brookes, the Australian software firm's boss, said that artificial intelligence was changing the type of skills that were needed. In common with many other software-makers, Atlassian's share price has plummeted as it reckons with AI models that are adept at coding, threatening its business.

The head chef of **Noma**, one of the world's best restaurants, resigned amid mounting accusations of whipping up a toxic culture in his kitchen. **René Redzepi** said he was stepping down after 23 years at the Danish restaurant that has championed Nordic cuisine and fermentation. Former employees led a protest outside Noma's pop-up in Los Angeles, which opened on Wednesday with seats at $1,500.

Figure of the day: 22%, Mr Trump's approval rating among Latinos, according to a CNN poll. Read how losing the Hispanic vote could cost Republicans the midterms.

Photograph: Getty Images

How to ease an energy shock

Expect more turbulence in markets on Thursday, as the world reacts to Iran's "most intense" operation of the war so far. The previous day Iran's regime vowed to "not allow even a single litre of oil" through the Strait of Hormuz, and said it regarded any vessel connected to America, Israel or its partners as a legitimate target. Projectiles struck three ships in or near the waterway; two tankers in the Persian Gulf were set ablaze. Shell, the world's largest LNG trader, declared *force majeure* on several contracts, excusing the company from meeting its obligations.

Governments are scrambling to control prices. On Wednesday the 32, mostly Western, members of the International Energy Agency announced that they would collectively release 400m barrels of oil from reserves, roughly equivalent to four days' worth of global consumption.

Meanwhile Donald Trump's promise that American warships would escort tankers through the strait "if needed" looks far-fetched. The US Navy has repeatedly denied shipowners' requests in recent days, according to Reuters.

Photograph: Reuters

American hopes for a Kurdish uprising dashed

The *peshmerga*, the military forces of Iraq's Kurdistan Region whose name translates to "those who face death", were poised to cross into Iran following America's and Israel's attacks. Now they are hesitating. Is it a ruse? The swift collapse of central authority in Iran, which America and Israel expected after killing Ali Khamenei and wrecking much of Iran's military, has not happened. Iran has aimed missiles and drones at the Kurdish region and warned their leaders against backing an insurgency. Turkey and Iraq have also rattled sabres, wary that Kurdish gains might embolden those dreaming of a Kurdish state.

Donald Trump has accepted the new reality. "I don't want the Kurds going in," he said—for their safety, of course. Israel, which tried to ignite an uprising, is probing other fronts. The loyalties of Iran's ethnic minorities are divided. Many are Shia and fear domination by more numerous Sunni neighbours and the foreigners waging war. But in the past Iran has unravelled when its regimes collapsed.

TURKEY
TURKMENISTAN
Tehran
IRAQ
IRAN
AFGHANISTAN
Chalamcheh
PAKISTAN
KUWAIT
The Gulf
BAHRAIN
QATAR
Strait of Hormuz
SAUDI ARABIA
UAE
OMAN
Arabian Sea
400 km
Iran, selected ethnic groups
Persian
Kurd
Azeri
Arab
Baluch
Other
Source: Dr M. Izady, Columbia University

Illustration: David Simons

America is racing China to get back to the Moon

On Thursday Jared Isaacman, the head of America's space agency, will outline what's next for its Artemis II mission—set to send astronauts round the Moon for the first time in 54 years. Originally scheduled for early February, lift-off has been repeatedly delayed by problems with the rocket's plumbing.

While Artemis II has been having various leaks plugged NASA has been busy re-engineering the entire Artemis programme. This reflects the growing realisation that China's less-ambitious programme might put its first astronauts on the Moon before America gets back there. America's previous lofty goal of landing Artemis III on the Moon next year has been replaced by a slower but steadier approach. NASA will first test out lunar landers developed by Elon Musk's SpaceX and Jeff Bezos's Blue Origin, and has deferred its planned Moon landing until 2028. In December Mr Isaacman warned Congress that if China pulls ahead, America "may never catch up".

Photograph: Getty Images

A Medicaid funding fight in Minnesota

In February the Trump administration launched a “War on Fraud”. A battle is playing out in a Minnesota courtroom. On Thursday parties will gather for a hearing over the federal government’s withholding of a quarter of a billion in funding for Medicaid — government health care for the poor—for the Democrat-run state.

The administration is linking the funding freeze to a sprawling welfare scandal thought to have cost Minnesota taxpayers hundreds of millions. Prosecutors have been bringing fraud-related charges since before Donald Trump’s second term, and have indicted almost 100 people. Now the Trump administration is pulling new levers—and more pain could be coming. If “Minnesota fails to clean up the systems”, warned Mehmet Oz, the federal director of Medicaid, it will “rack up a billion dollars” in withheld payments this year. The state argues it is trying to address fraud and that the government is “weaponising” health-care funding as political punishment.

Photograph: George Darrell

The grand old man of British art

At 88 years old, British painter David Hockney remains innovative and inquisitive. “A Year In Normandie And Some Other Thoughts About Painting” opened on Thursday at London’s Serpentine North gallery. Inspired by the Bayeux Tapestry, a Norman artefact, its title piece is a continuous frieze that wraps around the gallery interior.

There the resemblance to the 70m-long embroidered cloth ends. Mr Hockney’s work is no battle scene, but a pastoral panorama assembled from numerous digital paintings created on his iPad during the lockdowns of 2020. Its stillness recalls a second source: 14th-century scroll paintings from China.

To pass along it is to accompany the artist on a slow and deeply peaceful walk through the seasons. There are also ten new pictures in the gallery’s centre—five portraits, five semi-abstractions, meditating on similar natural themes, and looking at age-old themes through a sharp modern lens.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: What is another term for someone who works as a stable hand?

Wednesday: What was the biggest hit by DNCE, a rock band whose lead singer was Joe Jonas?

All of life is a foreign country.

Jack Kerouac